

Chapter 5: Understanding Child Behavior (The Root Cause Model)

Most parents try to fix behavior.

Smart parents understand behavior.

Because every behavior you see is not the real problem. It is a signal.

The Core Truth

Children do not misbehave to trouble you. They misbehave because they:

- Don't know what to do
- Can't express what they feel
- Are overwhelmed internally

Behavior is communication.

The Behavior Iceberg

What you see:

- Tantrums
- Anger
- Not listening
- Crying

What is underneath:

- Frustration
- Fear
- Tiredness
- Need for attention

If you fix only the surface, the behavior returns.

The 4 Root Causes of Misbehavior

1. Emotional Overload

- Child feels too much, too fast

Example:

- Loud crying over small issue
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2. Unmet Needs

- Hunger, sleep, attention

Example:

- Irritation before meals or bedtime
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3. Lack of Skills

- Child doesn't know how to respond

Example:

- Hitting instead of expressing anger
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4. Testing Boundaries

- Checking consistency

Example:

- Repeating the same behavior
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The SHIFT Response Model

Use this instead of reacting emotionally.

S – Stop Reacting

- Pause before responding
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H – Hold Calm

- Your calm stabilizes the situation
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I – Identify Cause

- Ask: What is behind this?
-

F – Fix the Root

- Address emotion or need
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T – Teach the Right Behavior

- Show what to do instead
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Common Parenting Mistake

Focusing only on stopping behavior.

Result:

- Behavior stops temporarily
- Returns again

Correct approach:

Understand → Then Guide

Real-Life Scenario

Child hits another child.

 Reaction: "Say sorry right now!"

Result:

- No learning

 Better approach: "You were angry." (pause) "We don't hit." "Use words when you're upset."

Result:

- Emotion understood
- Behavior corrected

Patterns to Watch

Notice when behavior happens:

- Before sleep
- During transitions
- When attention is divided

Patterns reveal causes.

When Behavior Repeats

Do not increase punishment.

Instead ask:

- Is the need still unmet?
 - Is the skill still missing?
 - Am I being inconsistent?
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If You Remember Only This

- Behavior is a signal, not the problem
 - Fix the cause, not just the action
 - Calm understanding leads to lasting change
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Quick Action (Apply Today)

- Identify one repeated behavior pattern
- Ask: What is causing this?
- Respond using SHIFT once

This is how behavior starts improving permanently.